Early Childhood Learning, Assessment, and Inclusive Practice

LET · early-childhood-education · BoardPrep lesson v2

Official examination scope

Original review of child development, play-based pedagogy, observation, family partnership, inclusion, and developmentally appropriate assessment. Scope is limited to the linked official board outline and curriculum references; this is not an exam prediction.

Learning objectives

- Interpret early development as interacting domains shaped by relationships, language, culture,
- opportunity, and context.
- Plan play, literacy, and numeracy experiences that are developmentally appropriate and
- responsive to observed learning.
- Use observation and assessment evidence to select a next step without diagnosing from a single
- behavior.
- Partner with families, include varied learners, and respond to child-protection concerns
- through school procedures.

1. Development in context

Development is integrated: physical, language and communication, cognitive, social-emotional, creative, and values learning influence one another. Children do not show every skill on one schedule, and opportunity, health, home language, relationships, and setting affect what an observation means. Use developmental expectations to notice and plan, never as a stand-alone diagnosis or a rigid cutoff. Start with the child’s strengths and the learning context, then choose a reachable next experience.

- Describe what the child did before interpreting what it might mean.
- Look for patterns across occasions, materials, partners, and settings.
- Plan an achievable next step while keeping the larger learning goal visible.

2. Play and guided learning

The MATATAG Kindergarten Curriculum describes play as a central approach and combines child-initiated activity with teacher support. In guided play, children retain meaningful choice; the teacher watches for a learning opportunity, introduces a useful word, asks an open question, models a strategy, or changes a material. A prompt should extend the child’s thinking rather than turn play into a disguised worksheet. Observe the response and reduce or increase support accordingly.

- Ask “What else could this block do?” to invite prediction and redesign.
- Offer a second container when a child is comparing capacity; let the child test it.
- Pause when teacher talk begins to dominate the child’s exploration.

3. Observation and assessment

Separate evidence from inference. “Placed three shells in a row and said ‘same’” is observable; “understands patterns” is an interpretation to check. Combine repeated observations, conversation, work samples, portfolios, and suitable checklists. The DepEd guide describes continuing documentation and use of the ECD checklist to identify learners who may need further assessment; a checklist is not a diagnosis. Choose the next activity from evidence, then check whether it helps. Share progress with families respectfully and protect confidential information.

- Record the setting, prompt, materials, and the child’s words or actions.
- Use more than one source before making a planning decision.

- Use assessment to improve instruction, not to rank young children.

4. Family partnership and inclusion

Families know children's interests, routines, languages, strengths, and ways of communicating. Ask open questions and use the family's knowledge to make school experiences more understandable and connected. Identify barriers in the room, schedule, instructions, materials, or response method. Adjust access while preserving the learning intention. Invite participation in ways that respect family circumstances; partnership is reciprocal, not a demand for one specific form of involvement.

- Ask which words, routines, or materials help a child join a new activity.
- Provide more than one way to respond when speech is not the target competency.
- Review whether an adjustment increases participation and belonging.

5. Oral language and multilingual learning

The MATATAG guide names the child's first language as a resource for literacy and communication. Build oral language through attentive conversation: listen, acknowledge the meaning, model a slightly expanded sentence, and invite another turn. A child may understand an idea before expressing it in the language used for instruction. Connect a new word to gesture, object, image, action, or familiar language; do not treat difference in language exposure as evidence of low ability.

- If a child names an object in a home language, acknowledge the meaning and offer the
- school-language word alongside it.
- Use turn-taking, songs, retelling, and purposeful talk rather than requiring repeated isolated
- pronunciation.
- Ask families which familiar words or stories can bridge a new classroom concept.

6. Emergent literacy and dialogic reading

Early literacy grows through meaningful encounters with oral language, stories, symbols, environmental print, and shared books. During reading, invite children to notice an illustration, predict what may happen, connect an event to experience, retell a part, or explain an idea. Point out print features when they serve the discussion, but keep comprehension and communication central. Re-reading a valued text can deepen prediction and vocabulary; it does not need to become a rapid drill of letter names.

- Pause for a child's interpretation before supplying the adult answer.
- Connect a print label to the real object or classroom purpose it represents.
- Use a child's retelling as evidence of meaning-making, not as a test of exact wording.

7. Everyday numeracy

The guide presents emergent literacy and basic numeracy as related learning. Build number and quantity ideas with objects children can move, compare, group, and count. Patterns can be noticed in steps, sounds, shells, or repeated classroom routines. Measurement and time make sense when connected to practical questions such as which container holds more or what happens before clean-up. Ask children to show how they know. Keep the representation tied to a real quantity or relation rather than relying on symbol copying alone.

- Let children distribute one cup to each classmate and check whether anyone has none or more
- than one.
- Compare lengths by aligning objects at a shared starting point.
- Ask what repeats in a movement or sound sequence before naming the pattern.

8. Relationships and social-emotional learning

Social-emotional learning develops within predictable, responsive relationships. A teacher can name a feeling tentatively, acknowledge a child's experience, help the child notice a safe choice, and remain nearby while the child regains participation. Routines, visual cues, transition warnings, and calm spaces can reduce unnecessary uncertainty. Peer conflict is an opportunity to teach communication, turn-taking, and repair; public shame or forced apologies do not teach the missing skill.

- Model a sentence such as "You both want the truck; let us find a way to take turns."
- Use a calm transition signal and a short preview before changing activities.
- Notice whether a routine helps the child rejoin the group.

9. Child protection and safeguarding

DepEd Order 40 identifies abuse, violence, exploitation, discrimination, bullying, and other forms of abuse as child-protection concerns in school. A teacher should recognize when a classroom issue falls within this scope and use the applicable school child-protection process. This lesson teaches the policy boundary and professional recognition only; exact reporting roles, timing, records, and follow-up must be checked in the current school procedure. Do not treat a covered concern as a routine behavior issue or make unsupported legal conclusions.

- Recognize the types of harm named in the policy scope.
- Use the school's applicable child-protection process when a concern arises.
- Verify local procedure rather than relying on a remembered deadline or role.

10. Responsive planning and inclusion

Plan from the intended learning and observed barrier. A child may show understanding by speaking, pointing, building, moving, drawing, or using a familiar symbol; choose a response mode that still demonstrates the target skill. Combine domains in an integrated activity when the connections are meaningful, such as sorting natural objects, describing a pattern, and collaborating on a display. If one child is not participating, examine access, clarity, pace, materials, and relationship before attributing the difficulty to the child.

- State the learning intention, then identify which task feature may prevent participation.
- Change the support or representation and observe the learner's response.
- Use the result to decide whether the activity, support, or next step needs revision.

Worked example: a shared story in two languages

Question: A child predicts an event in a home language while classmates use Filipino and English. What is a strong next teaching move?
1. Acknowledge and restate the child's prediction without treating the language difference as an error.
2. Offer the matching classroom-language word and connect it to the illustration.
3. Invite peers to explain which picture clues support or change their predictions.
Answer: The teacher keeps the idea central, uses the first language as an asset, and expands shared language through meaning.
Check: Did the child's contribution advance the same comprehension goal as peers?

Worked example: interpreting a number routine

Question: A child gives one shell to each of four toy animals, then notices an extra shell. What evidence and next step are useful?
1. Record the one-to-one distribution and the child's response to the extra object.
2. Offer another small distribution task with objects and people.
3. Ask the child to explain or show how to make each group equal.
Answer: Repeated concrete action and explanation provide evidence for responsive number learning.
Check: Do not infer mastery from one successful distribution or diagnose from one error.

Common misconceptions

- A developmental checklist identifies an area for further assessment; it is not a diagnosis.
- Play-based teaching includes intentional teacher observation and support; it is not unplanned
- free time.
- A child’s first language can support new learning rather than delay it.
- A child-protection concern calls for protective school referral, not teacher-led
- investigation.

Practice patterns

- Choose a next step from observed evidence.
- Distinguish the intended learning target from an access barrier.
- Explain how a teacher prompt extends child thinking without taking over.

Official scope references

Official scope: PRC Board Resolution No. 20, s. 2025, Annex A: LEPT alignment and specialization syllabi — Professional Regulatory Board for Professional Teachers / Professional Regulation Commission — https://www.prc.gov.ph/sites/default/files/2025-20%20Annex%20teachers.pdf

Instructional references

Instructional reference: MATATAG Kindergarten Curriculum Guide — Department of Education, Philippines — https://www.deped.gov.ph/wp-content/uploads/MATATAG-Kindergarten-CG.pdf
Instructional reference: DepEd Order No. 40, s. 2012: DepEd Child Protection Policy — Department of Education, Philippines — https://www.deped.gov.ph/2012/05/14/do-40-s-2012-deped-child-protection-policy/

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